Advanced Animations & Gestures in Flutter

Topic 08 — Cross-Platform Development

Student: Huỳnh Thiện Lộc (106230052)
Instructor: TS. Nguyễn Duy Nhật Viễn

Flutter Motion | Gesture Arena | 60/120 FPS VSync

Agenda

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2. Technical Requirements
3. Flutter Motion Architecture
4. Implicit vs Explicit Matrix
5. Explicit Lifecycle & Memory Safety
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7. UX Latency Thresholds

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9. Implicit Motion: State Interpolation
10. Explicit Gestures: Spring Physics
11. Automated Test Suite
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1. Animation & UX Roles

Pillar	Focus	Core Value
Spatial Continuity	State transitions	Eliminates cognitive friction and visual disorientation
Focus Guidance	Attention direction	Guides the eye to mutated or newly rendered elements
Touch Feedback	Sensory confirmation (< 100ms)	Confirms input instantly, prevents duplicate taps

2. Technical Requirements

Theoretical Foundations

- **Implicit Animations:** Declarative target interpolation.
- **Explicit Animations:** Imperative `AnimationController`.
- **Gesture Arena:** Touch conflict disambiguation.
- **Non-blocking UX:** Unconstrained touch pipeline.

Practical Deliverables

- **Implicit Card:** Shape, color, and size transitions.
- **Draggable Spring Card:** 2D pan + spring physics.
- **Morphing Button:** Non-blocking async feedback.
- **Automated Verification:** 5/5 test pass, 0 leaks.

3. Flutter Motion Architecture

```
[ Widgets Layer ]      Declarative widgets (AnimatedContainer, SlideTransition)
       ↓
[ Animation Layer ]    AnimationController, Tween<T>, CurvedAnimation
       ↓
[ Engine Scheduler ]   Ticker locks to OS hardware VSync (60Hz / 120Hz)
       ↓
[ GPU Rendering ]      Transform Layer mutations (bypasses widget subtree rebuilds)
```

4. Implicit vs Explicit Matrix

Dimension	Implicit Animations	Explicit Animations
Programming Model	Declarative	Imperative
Controller Management	Managed internally by Framework	Manual `AnimationController`
Memory Leak Risk	**0% (Zero Leak)**	**High** (If unreleased in `dispose()`)
Repeat / Reverse	Not supported	Full control (`repeat()`, `reverse()`)
Gesture Binding	Incompatible	Direct pan coordinate sync

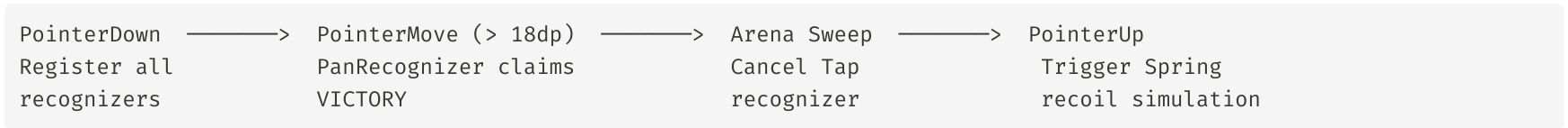
5. Explicit Lifecycle & Memory Safety

```
[initState()] ————————> [Ticker Hook] ————————> [Active Frames] ————————> [dispose()]
Initialize              Subscribe to            Frame-by-frame            Cancel Ticker &
AnimationController     VSync cadence           interpolation             release resources
```

Memory Leak Hazard:

Omitting `controller.dispose()` retains `TickerProvider` in the Engine Scheduler via a **Strong Reference**, preventing the Garbage Collector from freeing the unmounted route.

6. Gesture Arena & Disambiguation



- **2D Pan Tracking:** Real-time translation with dynamic tilt angle calculations.
- **SpringSimulation:** Natural damped harmonic recoil driven by release velocity.

7. UX Latency Thresholds

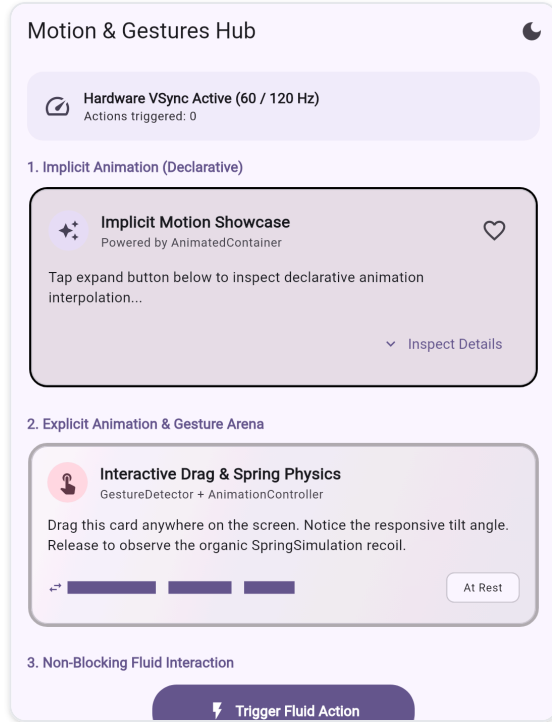
Latency	Classification	Practical Application
< 100 ms	Instant	Touch ripple, physical pressed states
150 – 350 ms	Natural (Gold Standard)	Navigation, element expansion, modal transitions
> 500 ms	Sluggish	Perceived as system lag; causes user friction

- **Non-Blocking UX:** Keep animations interruptible; never freeze user gestures.

8. Architecture & Motion Tokens

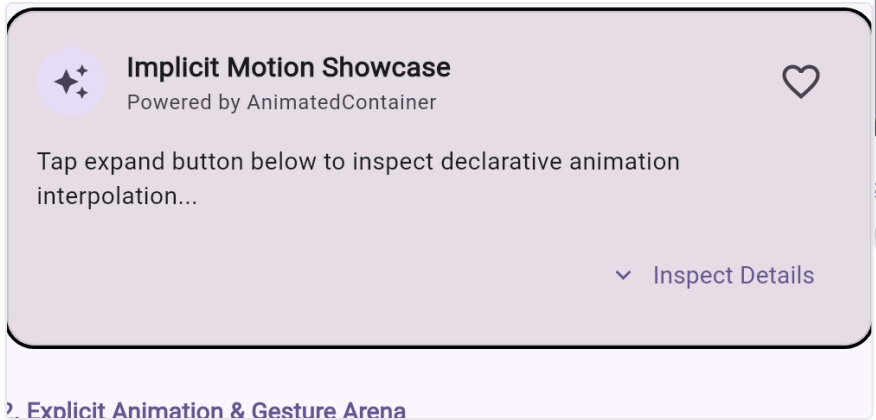
Demo App Structure (`week_04/app`):

- **MotionTokens (8dp Grid):**
  `space8` , `space16` , `space24` .
- **Three Independent Subsystems:**
  1. `ImplicitMotionCard` : Declarative interpolation.
  2. `DragSpringCard` : Gesture Arena + Spring physics.
  3. `MorphingActionButton` : Non-blocking async feedback.
- **VSync Synchronization:**
  Locked to 60Hz / 120Hz display refresh.

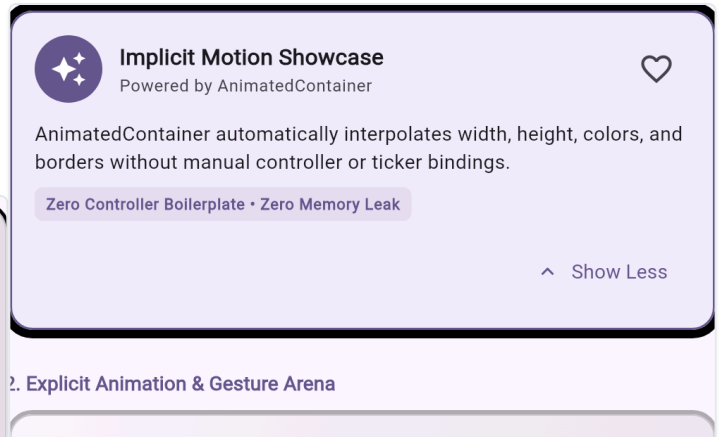


9. Implicit Motion: State Interpolation

Rest State



Expanded State

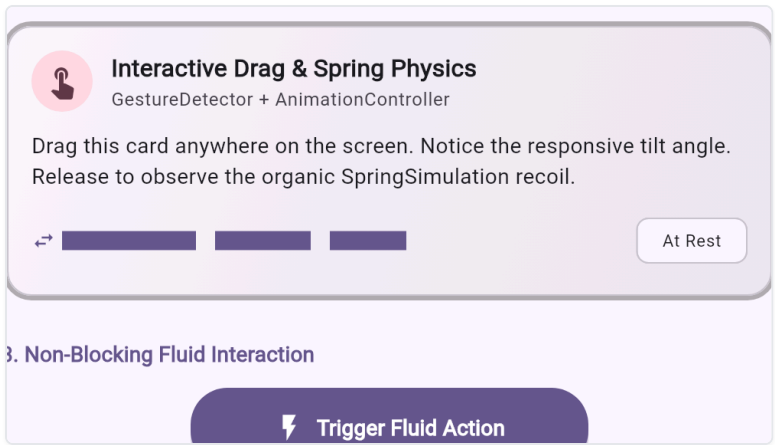


9. Implicit Motion: Mechanics

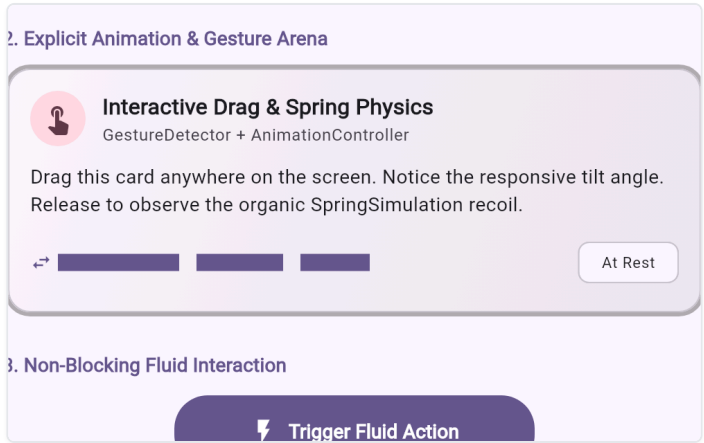
- **AnimatedContainer:** Interpolates property deltas across duration and curve.
- **Automatic State Sync:** Recomputes layout without external controllers.
- **Zero Resource Leaks:** Framework guarantees lifecycle teardown.

10. Explicit Gestures: Spring Physics

Rest State (Offset 0, 0)



Pan & Dynamic Tilt



10. Explicit Gestures: Mechanics

- **GestureDetector (`onPanUpdate`):** Synchronizes card translation and rotational tilt with pointer coordinates.
- **SpringSimulation (`onPanEnd`):** Runs physical recoil back to `(0, 0)` preserving release inertia.
- **Resource Teardown:** Explicit disposal in `State.dispose()`.

11. Automated Test Suite

5/5 Test Specifications Passed (100% ~ 2.5s):

1. **Launch & Layout:** Validates Material 3 rendering of all three modules.
2. **Implicit Motion:** Tests smooth interpolation across intermediate frames.
3. **Gesture Drag & Recoil:** Tests 80px drag displacement and spring return.
4. **Non-Blocking Async:** Verifies UI pipeline responsiveness during simulated network work.
5. **Memory Leak Teardown:** Confirms zero lingering tickers after widget destruction.

```
flutter test: All tests passed! (5/5)
dart analyze: No issues found!
```

12. Decision Matrix

Implicit Animations (Default)

- State-driven styling changes.
- Unidirectional transitions (A → B).
- **Benefits:** Zero memory leaks, minimal boilerplate, low maintenance.

Explicit Animations (Advanced)

- Repeating, looping, or reversible sequences.
- Direct gesture synchronization (Pan / Drag).
- **Requirement:** Rigorous `dispose()` lifecycle management.

13. References

- **Flutter Animations Overview:** docs.flutter.dev/ui/animations/overview
- **Implicit Animations Guide:** docs.flutter.dev/ui/animations/implicit-animations
- **Gestures & Disambiguation Arena:** docs.flutter.dev/ui/interactivity/gestures
- **AnimationController Class:** api.flutter.dev/flutter/animation/AnimationController-class.html
- **GestureArenaManager Class:** api.flutter.dev/flutter/gestures/GestureArenaManager-class.html
- **Material Design 3 Motion:** m3.material.io/styles/motion/overview/how-it-works